

Environmental impacts of AI are not “minor”, contrary to ai bros, they’re disgusting as hell, look at this new study!

Posted by u/N1KOBARonReddit • 0 points • 13 comments

AI systems already account for an estimated 15 to 20 percent of global data center electricity use, with a worldwide power demand of around 23 gigawatts, comparable to the average electricity consumption of the United Kingdom.

Their operation produces roughly 32.6 to 79.7 million tons of CO₂ annually, similar to the emissions of a large city like New York, and the massive energy demand has even led to considerations of reopening the decommissioned Three Mile Island nuclear power plant.

Cooling these data centers and power plants requires between 312.5 and 764.6 billion liters of water each year, roughly equivalent to the world’s annual bottled water consumption.

These figures are very conservative(!!), and they will only get higher over the years.(!!!)

Comments

u/JunKazama2024 • 1 points • 2026-01-04 13:59 UTC

So AI is 15% of 0.5-1.2% of global emissions? Much of that replacing less efficient labour that would consume and polluted more?

Im certainly not in favour of AI being put into every public facing service but it only looks particularly damaging to the environment if you are determined to ignore context. ChatGPT produced around 3000 tons of CO2 in 2024, tiktok produced 50 million

u/Express_Ad5083 • 1 points • 2026-01-01 13:09 UTC

Meat and Oil industries consume more water and pollute more.

u/JunKazama2024 • 1 points • 2026-01-04 13:55 UTC

u/Tragedy-of-Fives • 1 points • 2026-01-01 01:12 UTC

Here, I fixed it:

AI systems account for less than 1% of global electricity use, just 23 gigawatts, which is smaller than 5% of China's idle coal fleet and represents a rounding error in the global energy system.

Their operation produces roughly 32.6 to 79.7 million tons of CO₂ annually, which is less than 0.2% of global emissions, equivalent to what the cement industry emits in 4-10 days. For perspective, that's also 0.4-1.0% of what wildfires release each year.

Cooling these data centers requires between 312.5 and 764.6 billion liters of water each year, which is less than 0.02% of global freshwater withdrawal, or roughly what agriculture uses in 1-3 hours. It's also only 0.8-2% of the water needed to fill the Three Gorges Dam once.

I copied this comment from somewhere else. No credit to me for this.

u/N1KOBARonReddit • 1 points • 2026-01-01 02:11 UTC

These comparisons are insanely unhinged. For example, why the hell are you comparing AI to GLOBAL FRESHWATER WITHDRAWAL!!?!?! If it ever gets comparable to that metric, civilization would be pretty much destroyed, if not absolutely vaporized.

We're dealing with very conservative statistics, that will only get higher.

By the way we always have enough energy somewhere, the key is when, where, how, etc.

These statistics will definitely strain local areas.

If you want to use this logic, how about not give a shit about any environmental issue at all, since we can compare it to cosmic metrics.

Global plastic waste would be absolutely negligible if we bring up the fact that it is 0.000000000000000002% of the mass of the Sun.

What's scary is that it is already comparable to significant metrics likethr world's annual bottled water consumption?

u/FlashyNeedleworker66 • 1 points • 2025-12-31 13:51 UTC

There Mile island was open in like 2019, and turned off for cost reasons. It hasn't been sitting there shut off since the accident.

u/Rastyn-B310 • -5 points • 2025-12-31 11:12 UTC

Agrochemicals and sewage are more detrimental by far to the environment than data centers are. Focus on consuming less product and producing less waste.

u/Zomhuahua • 6 points • 2025-12-31 13:16 UTC

I'm going to start holding my poop just so people can keep making italian brainrot and Charlie Kirk shitplsts.

u/DesertFroggo • -15 points • 2025-12-31 02:55 UTC

Data centers are part of the environment.

u/big_shobeth • 5 points • 2025-12-31 23:39 UTC

Are you okay up there? I know ai usage causes brain damage but like, utter derangement? At best, weak bait at worst I fear for the absolute delusion ai causes people

u/DesertFroggo • -2 points • 2025-12-31 23:50 UTC

Am I wrong?

Humans are part of nature. We evolved on this planet just like any other life. The environment has gone through episodes of much greater destruction than data centers could ever cause.

u/big_shobeth • 4 points • 2026-01-01 00:20 UTC

Human built structures do not count as part of the natural environment, any period of greater destruction was natural forces we are an unnatural force driving comparable destruction.

u/DesertFroggo • -1 points • 2026-01-01 03:23 UTC

>Human built structures do not count as part of the natural environment

>we are an unnatural force

Where did we come from?

u/big_shobeth • 2 points • 2026-01-01 03:37 UTC

While we are natural the things we do are not our most harmful things are synthetically made by us (plastics and chemicals) additionally a large chunk of the harm we do is technically natural but we create it at unnatural levels such as carbon pollution we've essentially disrupted the natural carbon cycle.

Human structures are not natural they are entirely constructed by us many of which cause damage to the natural environment

u/DesertFroggo
• 0 points
• 2026-01-01 07:02 UTC

>Human structures are not natural they are entirely

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by us
many of
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to the
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Many
forms of
life have
been on
this
planet
whose
activities
damaged
existing
environments,
only to
make
room for
new
environments.
That's
how life
works.
Oxygen
was, at
one
point in
this
planet's
history,
foreign
to the
contemporary
environment.

Nobody
has
enough
of a
view of
the
bigger
picture
of
nature

on this
planet
to
declare
that
humans
don't fit
in it.
Humans
are part
of
nature.
We
evolved
from the
natural
process
of life
here,
and the
things
we build
are part
of our
natural
inclinations.